

Synthetic Solved Case Files: Vancouver Police Department - Major Crime Section

Case File #VAN-2023-001: The Gastown Ghost

- **Date Reported:** 2023-03-15
- **Location:** Heritage building housing an art gallery, Gastown, Vancouver.
- **Crime Type:** Burglary (High-Value Sculptures)
- **Modus Operandi (MO):** Perpetrator disabled motion sensors using targeted infrared emitters. Gained entry via a rooftop skylight, rappelling down using climbing gear. Selectively stole two specific bronze sculptures, ignoring paintings and cash. No signs of forced entry on the skylight; likely manipulated the locking mechanism. Extreme care taken – minimal forensic evidence left (used gloves, specific non-common athletic shoe). Time of entry estimated between 01:30-03:30 AM. Security log analysis showed sensor bypass coincided with brief, localized power fluctuations typical of nearby construction, initially masking the event.
- **Key Evidence:** Trace amounts of unusual red clay found near the skylight access point (not native to the area), partial shoe print matching a limited-edition European athletic shoe, analysis of dark web forums revealed pre-sale inquiries for similar sculptures, recovered infrared emitter schematic from suspect's cloud storage (post-warrant).
- **Resolution:** Clay analysis traced it to a specific pottery studio in Burnaby. Shoe print narrowed down potential suspects. Dark web monitoring flagged inquiries linked (via anonymized crypto transaction analysis) to a known fence. Surveillance near the pottery studio and cross-referencing with known associates of the fence led to **Julian Vance**, a former structural engineer with climbing experience and known art world contacts. A search warrant confirmed possession of climbing gear, specialized tools, and digital evidence linking him to the planning and sale inquiries.
- **Status:** Closed. Julian Vance convicted.

Case File #VAN-2023-002: The Credential Creeper

- **Date Reported:** 2023-05-20 (Multiple victims reporting over 3 weeks)
- **Location:** Victims primarily residents of Kitsilano, Mount Pleasant, and downtown Vancouver condos.
- **Crime Type:** Phishing / Financial Fraud / Identity Theft
- **MO:** Victims received sophisticated phishing emails/SMS messages impersonating BC Hydro or Canada Post, citing billing errors or delivery issues. Links led to convincing cloned login portals hosted on rapidly changing domains

registered through offshore providers. Harvested credentials (banking, utility, CRA) were used to access accounts. Perpetrator then applied for credit cards using stolen identities, intercepted mail, and made numerous online purchases shipped to temporary P.O. boxes or used for gift card fraud. Utilized public Wi-Fi hotspots (libraries, cafes) combined with multi-layer VPNs for obfuscation. Showed patience, often waiting weeks after credential theft before initiating fraud.

- **Key Evidence:** Analysis of phishing domain registration patterns (specific registrar, naming conventions), digital forensics recovery of malware script from one victim's device (keylogger deployed post-credential theft), shared P.O. box addresses used for fraudulent deliveries, CCTV footage from ATM withdrawals linked to mule accounts (though perp used disguises), linguistic analysis of phishing emails showing specific grammatical quirks.
- **Resolution:** VPD Cybercrime unit identified the pattern of domain registrations and hosting providers. Malware analysis revealed unique code signatures. Cross-referencing P.O. box usage and ATM withdrawal locations/times helped build a geographic profile. Linguistic analysis pointed towards a suspect with English as a second language and specific European language patterns. This, combined with flagged suspicious activity reports (SARs) from banks regarding mule accounts, led to **Anya Sharma**, a recent immigrant with IT skills and prior minor fraud charges in her home country. Surveillance and digital warrants confirmed her activities.
- **Status:** Closed. Anya Sharma convicted.

Case File #VAN-2023-003: The Waterfront Wipe

- **Date Reported:** 2023-07-10
- **Location:** Marina office, Coal Harbour, Vancouver.
- **Crime Type:** Data Theft / Sabotage (Targeted Deletion)
- **MO:** Perpetrator gained physical access to the marina office after hours, likely tailgating an employee or using a copied keycard (no forced entry). Accessed the main administrative server directly. Used a USB device containing custom malware to exfiltrate sensitive client data (boat ownership, payment details) and then initiated a logic bomb that wiped specific mooring contract records, causing significant administrative chaos. Targeted deletions focused on contracts associated with a specific international shipping company. Left behind a generic USB drive casing (internals removed).
- **Key Evidence:** Forensic analysis of the server logs showed unauthorized access times and data transfer patterns consistent with USB usage, recovered fragments of the malware code revealing specific deletion commands targeting keywords

related to the shipping company, analysis of keycard access logs showed an anomaly (a card used outside its usual hours), partial fingerprint recovered from the discarded USB casing.

- **Resolution:** Malware analysis indicated a sophisticated actor familiar with the marina's specific software. Keycard log anomaly pointed to a low-level employee, **David Chen**, who had recently been passed over for promotion and had access patterns matching the time of the breach. Fingerprint analysis matched Chen. Investigation revealed Chen had connections to a rival shipping company and significant gambling debts. He confessed to being paid to steal the data and wipe the records.
- **Status:** Closed. David Chen convicted.

Case File #VAN-2023-004: The Granville Grabber

- **Date Reported:** Ongoing reports June-August 2023
- **Location:** Small retail businesses (cafes, bookstores, boutiques) along Granville Street, Vancouver.
- **Crime Type:** Serial Petty Theft (Distraction Method)
- **MO:** Perpetrator, typically working during moderately busy daytime hours, used distraction techniques. One common method involved feigning a medical issue (coughing fit, dizziness) near the cash register while an accomplice lifted wallets/phones from nearby purses or staff areas. Another involved creating a small commotion (spilled drink, loud argument on phone) to draw attention while lifting merchandise near the entrance. Perpetrator varied appearance slightly (hats, glasses) but maintained a consistent nervous energy. Targeted items were usually easily concealable and quickly pawned.
- **Key Evidence:** Consistent witness descriptions of the primary actor's mannerisms despite appearance changes, pattern analysis of incident times and locations, CCTV footage from multiple locations showing the same individual (and sometimes a suspected accomplice), recovery of stolen items from specific pawn shops known for lax ID checks.
- **Resolution:** VPD analysts mapped the incidents, identifying hotspot locations and times. Distributed bulletins with suspect descriptions and MO to Granville Street businesses and patrol officers. Pawn shop detail tracked transactions involving the stolen goods. A plainclothes officer recognized the primary suspect, **Michael Bellweather**, based on mannerisms during an attempted distraction theft. Bellweather, with a history of petty crime, confessed and implicated his accomplice.
- **Status:** Closed. Michael Bellweather and accomplice convicted.

Case File #VAN-2023-005: The Forged Canvas

- **Date Reported:** 2023-09-05
- **Location:** Private art collector's residence, West Vancouver.
- **Crime Type:** Art Forgery / Fraud
- **MO:** Perpetrator, posing as an art restoration specialist, gained the trust of an elderly, wealthy art collector. Offered to perform "conservation work" on a valuable painting (a known Canadian landscape artist). Gained access to the painting for several weeks. Returned a near-perfect forgery while keeping the original. Used chemically aged canvases, period-appropriate pigments (identified later via spectroscopy), and mimicked the artist's brushwork meticulously. The forgery passed initial visual inspection by the owner. Fraud discovered months later when the owner attempted to get a new insurance appraisal.
- **Key Evidence:** Expert analysis by museum conservators identified microscopic inconsistencies in pigment composition and canvas aging techniques in the forgery, detailed financial investigation revealed the suspect had recently acquired historically accurate (but expensive) art supplies, digital forensics found deleted image fragments of the original painting on the suspect's devices, witness testimony from art supply stores.
- **Resolution:** The victim identified the "specialist" as **Dr. Evelyn Reed**, an art historian with documented financial difficulties and expertise in the specific artist's period. Forensic accounting linked her purchases to the materials needed for the forgery. Digital evidence and expert analysis confirmed her involvement. The original painting was recovered from a private dealer Reed was attempting to sell it to discreetly.
- **Status:** Closed. Dr. Evelyn Reed convicted.

Case File #VAN-2024-006: The Impersonation Intruder

- **Date Reported:** 2024-01-10
- **Location:** Apartment building, Yaletown, Vancouver.
- **Crime Type:** Identity Theft / Burglary
- **MO:** Perpetrator used stolen identity information (likely obtained via prior phishing or data breach - linked possibly to Case #VAN-2023-002 victims) to create fake identification documents. Used these documents to impersonate a resident who was known to be travelling internationally. Convinced building concierge/security to grant access to the victim's apartment. Once inside, stole high-value portable electronics, jewelry, and personal documents (passports, SIN cards). Left minimal signs of entry, appearing as a legitimate resident entry.
- **Key Evidence:** High-quality forged ID recovered from a related incident, concierge witness statement describing the impersonator's confident demeanor,

forensic analysis of stolen documents' use in subsequent unrelated fraud attempts, CCTV footage showing suspect's entry/exit (though appearance was altered), link established between the victim of this case and a previous phishing wave victim list.

- **Resolution:** The pattern of using stolen identities specifically of travelling residents was noted. The quality of the forged ID suggested a skilled forger. Cross-referencing with known associates of Anya Sharma (Case #VAN-2023-002) and monitoring communications led investigators to **Leo Martel**, a graphic designer known to associate with Sharma and possess skills in document forgery. Martel was arrested during an attempt to use another stolen identity. Evidence found linked him to multiple impersonation burglaries.
- **Status:** Closed. Leo Martel convicted.

Case File #VAN-2024-007: The Terminal Takedown

- **Date Reported:** 2024-02-28
- **Location:** Port of Vancouver, Container Terminal Area.
- **Crime Type:** Cargo Theft (Targeted Electronics)
- **MO:** A coordinated team exploited known gaps in security shift changes. An insider (terminal employee) provided information on specific high-value electronics container locations and schedules. An external team used forged shipping documents and a cloned transport truck to gain access to the yard during a brief window (approx. 20 minutes) during the night shift change. They located the specific container, loaded it onto their truck, and exited before the incoming shift completed security checks. The stolen container was later found abandoned and empty in a remote industrial area in Surrey.
- **Key Evidence:** Discrepancies in entry/exit logs for the transport truck, analysis of employee access records identifying potential insiders working during relevant shifts, recovery of forged documents showing specific printing/paper inconsistencies, GPS data from the abandoned container's tracker (activated post-theft), anonymous tip received regarding unusual activity involving a specific trucking company.
- **Resolution:** Log analysis and internal investigation focused suspicion on terminal logistics coordinator **Samir Khan**, who had access to schedules and manifests and exhibited unusual financial activity. The anonymous tip led investigators to a small, independent trucking company. Surveillance of the company and Khan revealed connections. GPS data corroborated the route taken to the dump site. Khan confessed to providing information for a cut of the profits, implicating the trucking company owner and drivers.
- **Status:** Closed. Samir Khan and associated trucking crew convicted.

Case File #VAN-2024-008: The Digital Defacer

- **Date Reported:** 2024-03-10 (Multiple incidents over a week)
- **Location:** Websites of several Vancouver-based environmental NGOs.
- **Crime Type:** Cybercrime / Website Defacement / Denial-of-Service (DoS)
- **MO:** Perpetrator exploited a known vulnerability (unpatched CMS plugin) common across the targeted NGO websites. Gained administrative access and replaced homepage content with political manifestos criticizing the organizations' stances. Also launched minor DoS attacks (SYN floods) from a small botnet of compromised IoT devices (smart TVs, routers) to temporarily disrupt service. Used pseudonyms ("EcoWarriorX") in defacement messages. Took steps to wipe server logs but missed some system-level logs on host providers' infrastructure.
- **Key Evidence:** Analysis of the CMS vulnerability exploited, identification of the specific plugin version, recovery of partial server logs showing login IP addresses (proxied, but consistent pattern), analysis of the botnet command-and-control traffic patterns, linguistic analysis of the manifestos, digital trail from cryptocurrency donations linked to the pseudonym.
- **Resolution:** VPD Cybercrime unit identified the common vulnerability. Log analysis, despite wiping attempts, revealed originating IP patterns pointing to a specific university network. Botnet traffic analysis helped fingerprint the attacker's control methods. Manifesto language and crypto donation trails led investigators to **Chloe Daniels**, a university student and activist known for radical views and advanced coding skills. Forensic analysis of her devices confirmed her control of the botnet and creation of the defacement content.
- **Status:** Closed. Chloe Daniels convicted.

Case File #VAN-2024-009: The Strata Saboteur

- **Date Reported:** 2024-04-05
- **Location:** Luxury condo building, False Creek, Vancouver.
- **Crime Type:** Vandalism / Mischief (Targeted)
- **MO:** Perpetrator repeatedly caused targeted damage within the building over several weeks, always avoiding direct CCTV view. Incidents included cutting specific fibre optic cables in service shafts (affecting only certain floors/units), jamming high-end apartment door locks with specialized adhesives, and minor, easily cleaned graffiti using specific chemical markers in stairwells frequented by specific residents. Actions seemed designed to cause maximum inconvenience and expense to particular individuals or the strata council, rather than random vandalism.
- **Key Evidence:** Pattern analysis showing targeting of specific residents/floors, type of damage requiring specific tools/knowledge (fibre optics, adhesives),

chemical analysis of graffiti markers (uncommon brand), discovery of discarded adhesive applicator near one scene, internal building disputes documented in strata meeting minutes.

- **Resolution:** The targeted nature pointed towards an internal dispute. Review of strata minutes highlighted ongoing, bitter conflicts involving resident **Marcus Thorne**, a retired engineer who felt unfairly treated regarding noise complaints and strata fees. Chemical analysis matched the graffiti marker to a brand Thorne was known to use for hobbies (model building). Investigators found online purchases linked to Thorne for the specific adhesive and fibre optic tools. Confronted with the evidence and patterns, Thorne confessed.
- **Status:** Closed. Marcus Thorne convicted.